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About 3,500 words

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Home for Christmas

by Burt Burlington

The greenish hue from surrounding lightyears tall nebulas, projected on the windshield like trees in a dense forest. Floating through this natural and magical, almost nostalgic to earth, space biome. Flickering stars, vast distances from me, decorating the abyss with beautiful white, yellow and red colors. A comet with a long stunning white dust tail spans from my right rear window to my back left window. Luringly peaceful in the daunting depths of space, it almost resembled a Christmas tree. *Ah, Christmas Eve...* I look forward to seeing my family again for Christmas; I haven't spoken to them since... *I can't even remember the last time I spoke to them.* I am sure I haven't talked to them since I got assigned my latest mission, but that has only been three weeks. Celebrating that ancient holiday was the happiest time of the year for me: decorating the tree with my father, baking mealworms cookies with my mother, and telling my niece and nephew I would visit Santa Clause on Neptune before coming home every December. I snickered in my loneliness while drifting further away from them. My nostalgia trip was cut short by a high-tone beep, followed by another identical one.

"You are entering STX prohibited space," a robotic voice proclaimed; "abandon now, or we will use force."

Calmly, I started initiating contact with the radio channel.

“I repeat, you are entering STX prohibited space-.”

I interrupted the automated message; "this is agent 7447, sent by DIC regarding prisoner 22A. Permission to land?" Waiting passionately, I already drifted closer to planet Yoru. "Permission to land?" I repeated

“This is STX communication tower, permission to land.”

I didn't have to move my steering wheel much to face the desert prison planet.

#

The planet Yoru consisted of dark brown desert with huge canyons running down the planet's facade like scars. On the edge of one of the 5-mile-deep canyons stood Yoru STX Supermax Penitentiary. An impressive building consisting of iron and titanium, spanning kilometers across the surface in the form of a spearhead. The structure is presumably a strange sight for any lowbrow crawling reptilians native to the Yorurian desert landscape.

"It's been a few years since we have last welcomed a bounty hunter inside our gates that wasn't behind bars, Mr. Adem,"

The chubby Guard Master said, laughing at his own joke, while entering Cellblock Σ. The greenish man was of the Fjetz race, a highly respected sub-species with slits as eyes through which they could see ultraviolet. Their average lifespan was between 150 to 500 years, making them more experienced than other races on average. He had nothing on his person, no keycards, batons, or tasers. Only a state-of-the-art AP-12 Pistol that could only be fired by a specific person by use of a fingerprint.

"You've ever been here before, agent 4774?" the Guard Master asked me while passing multiple cells.

"Not that I can remember," I said while looking at the countless cells going multiple floors up. All doors made out of reinforced steel; through the eye slits, I saw different skin colors and varying amounts of eyes staring back at me.

"Well, sir, I am sure you haven't then because the Yoru STX Supermax Penitentiary is an unforgettable diamond of architectural prowess. Just like a diamond, it is impossible to pierce in or out of it; that is why we dub it 'The Diamond'. Situated on the planet Yoru and far away from any planet harboring life, we keep the people in the galaxy safer than ever before." The guard unlocks the large heavy door at the end of Cellblock Σ by scanning his implanted chip in his right palm.

"By a collaboration between the Department of Intergalactic Crime and the Democracy of Galactic Worlds, they founded the secure STX Supermax Penitentiary in 431-."

"I get it, sir; I appreciate your prepared speech and all, telling me how secure STX is. But I am here because Prisoner 22A escaped your prison less than three weeks ago, and I am assigned to bring him back. So, shall we take a look at the camera footage of that night so I can be on my way?"

The chubby veteran stared at me begrudgingly; his eye slits seemingly even tighter. He turned back and walked a few paces, "this way."

We arrived in one of the many security rooms. Large 4000-pixel wide screens covered the walls. Every separate screen was focused on a single inmate. Ya-Yings, Troxi's, some humans, diversity a plenty. The Guard master walked up to a guard sitting at the control station. "Phinikin, show all camera perspectives of the night prisoner 22A escaped."

"Yes, master sir," and the guard followed his orders. Almost instantly, all the screens viewed different sides of the prison: Hallways, cells, yard, the spikey north tower.

"You see here; this is where prisoner 22A was supposed to be for that night," the Guard Master pointed at an empty cell. "He knew that prisoner attendance would be notarized by exact weight and infrared temperature map of the occupant, which are measured in every cell, specific to every inmate."

"But there is no one in that cell?" I said, looking at the screen.

"We thought the same thing until we looked inside the cell. Forward to that Phinikin" the Guard master looked back at the screen. "Here, see," on screen, the guards drag from under the bed a fresh guard with a fatal head wound from an electrical-charged pistol, covered with blood, "the guard was a human, one of the few we have. The inmate ripped off the guard's index finger, which he used to shoot the guard with his own fingerprint-locked pistol."

I looked up at the screen, impressed by the ingenuity.

"And if you liked that, you would be interested to hear this," the Guard Master continued. "The guard was originally severely heavier than the prisoner, but he drastically lost a bunch of weight in the last few months, which the guard himself couldn't explain. He thought he was lucky, but I think we can see that wasn't the case." He sighed and looked at the ground together with Phinikin. He took a big breath. "We believe the inmate in question was setting this mysterious weight loss in place, in order for him to match his own body weight."

I was so impressed I didn't even notice doing the cliché rubbing-chin-with-index-finger-and-thumb out of intrigue.

"And I can tell you another thing, Mr. Adem. No one, absolutely no one, knows outside of us how attendance is being measured. Only I, Phinikin, the warden, and now you know." The guard looked back at the collection of screens.

While rubbing my chin, I squinted my eyes. *Only us four? But then one of you would have to have informed him?* I wanted to be careful what I would say next or convey to them.

"Here, look," the guard said enthusiastically, "here, this is one of the only times we can see Prisoner 22A on the cameras." With great assurance, he pointed with his green "finger" to the top of a hairy head sliding by on one of the screens. "The facility has 4,212 cameras; the only ones where we could see him on was 3. Which was this one where we see the top of his head in hallway C, his feet when he climbed on the ceiling on camera 37A, and far away in the distance when he was running outside on camera 94K."

"Was that the last time you saw him?" I asked, looking into the Guard Master slits.

"Yes."

"Did he steal a ship?"

"No."

"So he is still on Yoru?"

"To our knowledge, yes. But we have yet to find anything with our search missions."

"Alright, show me his prison profile."

The Guard Master nods, "pull it up, Phinikin."

The employee does what he is ordered to, and up pops an image of the most recent picture of prisoner 22A. A caucasian humanoid with an aggressive black beard and untidy haircut. "Here he is, Tyne Preater, convicted for resisting arrest, endangering police officers, murder, and escape from prison."

I walked closer and took a better look. Somehow, this absolute stranger felt a bit, familiar.

"He is one of the more intelligent people we have incarcerated at STX. He always seems to be in the right place and is always prepared for anything. He's cold, calculated, and doesn't like to waste time."

"Then I should better go and find him now. What is your hypothesis, did he leave Yoru or not?" I asked the Guard Master.

"My professional opinion, no. He needs to find a ship. No ship has been taken from the STX hangers, and every vessel in 800.000 km is monitored, so we believe he is still on Yoru.

"And did you check every ship leaving and entering Yoru in that time?"

"What do you think our officers are doing with your ship as we speak? We fit a GPS tracker to every ship that flies in STX space."

"Great, I have nothing to hide," I didn't flinch. "Then I suppose I will start my journey scavenging the Yoru surface." I started walking to the door.

"Excellent. Oh, and when you want to leave Yoru, even if you found Preater or not, you must report here, and we will remove the tracker. We can't let anybody leave without authorization."

I waved my hand in confirmation.

"Oh, and Agent 4774, we want Preater alive. It is not up to you to liquidate him."

"I am a bounty hunter, not a killer."

I turned back, and continued on my journey.

#

After floating over the Yoru surface, monitoring any movement or infrared signals, there was no sign of Preater. I investigated some conspicuous caves and canyons, but no sign of any life form except for Yorurian rodents and mindless Sescentipedes. In the far distance, I spotted the mining excavating building—a large lonely metal structure in the middle of the

Yoru desert. Instead of transporting all the resources meant for the STX Supermax Penitentiary, they utilized Yoru's rich crust of iron and titanium by mining it here. I landed near the decrepit rusty steel skeletal structure. With my combat boots, I quickly traversed the harsh terrain of Yoru to the building. A metal wall was forced open on the side, granting access to the inside. I believed I found Preater's hideout, but only for a second. I inspected the damage done to the wall from close by; the broken part of the metal sheet had already rusted way more than the intact sheets, meaning that this had been deprived open way before Preater escaped prison three weeks ago. Still, I grabbed my infrared flashlight and electrical-charged pistol, ready for anything. The building had been abandoned for some time; pipes that used to transport water were hanging from the ceiling, metal beams were close to collapsing. Metal catwalks hanging from the top looked like they would fall any second now. The only colors I could see were grey steel, darkness, brown rust, and my red searchlight. The industrial complex was dusty because of the millions of tons of stone excavated from the Yoru crust.

I stepped through a corridor into the large hall where all the iron and titanium would be stored. With my arms crossed in front of me, wielding my pistol and my flashlight, scanning the room for life. Directly above me, I heard the creaking of metal. I quickly stepped forward and looked up at the catwalk above me. On it, seemingly ready to pounce on me, stood a dark shadow who I could only imagine being Preater. It seemed to be wielding a lead pipe. I aimed my pistol and IR flashlight at it. I saw an aggressive white glow silhouette on a black background, ready to attack.

"Hands up! I am a bounty hunter sent by the DIC."

"I know," the unknown person replied.

The voice, so recognizable. But from where?

In my confusion, I didn't see Preater take a run for it. He was now halfway across the catwalk, running away from me.

“Freeze!”

With my electrical charged pistol, I shot out one of the poles that the catwalk hung off to warn the jailbreaker. The pole I hit melted, and the catwalk started to crumble. Preater was just in time to reach solid footing when the catwalk collapsed. I loaded my pistol with a new high-fusion bullet and ran after him. Climbing my way up—by way of the fallen catwalk where Preater jumped to—I saw him escape into a dark hallway.

"You are ruining everything; we will never get out!" he yelled as he went deeper into the hallway.

Lucky me, my target has a multiple identity disorder. "Calm down, Preater; everything will be fine, and return to how it was."

"You don't understand. I am doing this for us, all of us's" the darkness said.

"We can talk about this, Preater..." I said, cautiously stepping into the darkness.

The floor and walls were lined with pipes. Quietness arose. It felt as if Preater had disappeared back in time. Walking through the modern metal ruins, I spotted peculiar damage. Multiple melted steel beams like the one I shot earlier. *There had been various gunfights here through the years.*

"Maybe we can meet on a middle ground?" I said while walking through the hallway with my eyes peeled—still no response from the just recently very talkative man.

"What is it that you want?" I said, trying to make Preater give away his location.

“For you to die!”

Preater yelled, seemingly appearing out of thin air.

He hit me on my upper back with the lead pipe, knocking me down on the ground. My pistol and lamp rolled down the hallway. I turned on my back, Preater swinging with his lead pipe again. Desperately, I tried blocking it with my hands. I shielded my head from the lethal impact. I managed to grab hold of the pipe, pulling it towards me. Doing that, Preater falling

on top of me, giving me a chance to look at his face. The beard he had on his prisoner profile had been shaven off, but his face was more recognizable than ever. It was my own.

Frightened, I pushed Preater off myself, granting him full access to the lead pipe.

“Why-. How are... how do you look like me?” I said, stumbling with my words out of utter confusion.

“You look like me,” Preater said, as convinced as a person can be. “And I need you to die.”

He charged his swing with the pipe and smashed it on the ground, nearly hitting me. The thrilling sensation of the pipe hitting the metal beneath would've felt like a 1000-volt shockwave through your arms. A chance for me to escape. I stood up and ran into one of the splintering hallways. My feet tapping on the metal frames, I ran as far as possible.

“You don't know, what you are doing, Adem.” The voice from the embodiment of my uncanny reflection echoed through the hallways.

"If that is still your name. Or are you going by Agent 4773, 4774, or 4775? Excuse me; I lost count."

I walked into a T-formed junction. I scanned the two abysses in search of daylight. Sadly, there was none. I saw a stray rock lying on the ground. I threw the stone in the left hallway—the rock scattering over the metallic floors. While the rock was singing its melody, I climbed—as silently as the metal allowed—into the ceiling above. Snuggling between the pipes hanging over top, I could hear Preater's footsteps nearing.

"I have been waiting for you since the day I made the same mistake you were risking to make. Saving you and me from the faith all of us were given."

At that moment, Preater stepped underneath me, unaware I was there. *Shit, my gun.*

Preater was wielding my pistol and had my flashlight tucked in his pants. Holding my breath, trying not to give a single sound cue, or else I would be dead.

"I only need a little cooperation from you. I can show you proof," he said, scanning both hallways. "Or else I can just leave with your ship," he said when he walked into one of the hallways, "and leave you to die."

#

"If you don't want to learn the truth, then so be it!" Preater proclaimed when he exited the excavation building through the same hole, I ventured through earlier. My ship neatly parked a few hundred feet out into the Yoru desert.

"You made the wrong decision, but you will be happy you did in the end." while proudly walking to his escape vehicle. Preater was forcing his way in through the butterfly doors. At that moment, I shot from under the landing skit, grabbing Preaters legs. Preater dropped to the floor, and the pistol fell on the brown rocky sand. I stood up and turned around to the dropped gun. Preater, crawling on the floor towards the pistol, "you don't know what you're doing."

I grabbed the gun and turned to Preater, lying on the floor. Preater tried to stand up.

"Sit the fuck down!" I held the pistol with stretched arms. Preater sat on his ass, naively shielding the potential blast with his bare hands. "Wait, you will doom all of us!"

"What the fuck are you saying?"

"This." Preater pulled the infrared flashlight from his pants and pointed it toward me. The red light revealed my electromagnetic radiation.

"See," Preater said, looking at my chest.

I carefully looked at my core, trying not to lose sight of Preater. My body, from my toes to the edges of my hands, were icy dark blue, almost black. Yet a square of blinding white came from my chest. I noticed the immense heat coming from my chest for the first time.

"That is your radioactive power core, 4774," You are an android," Preater said, pointing the red light back at himself, revealing the same temperature map, "and so am I, 4773."

I lost all strength in my muscle... *or gears, or springs, whatever you call them!* My arms hung beside my body like car wash curtains.

"But my family... Christmas...?"

"All programmed to make you obey orders," Preater said, mirroring precisely the same dejectedness on our faces.

"No..." I said, not daring to look at me or Preater, myself or him.

"Do you know *anything* about them besides Christmas? Other memories? Like your first kiss?"

I was looking at the ground and my feet.

"You are a bounty hunter android, sent as sole task to hunt me down and put me against bars forever, as for androids like us can't die to old age. Just like I had been ordered to put agent 4772 behind bars when he had escaped..." Preater told in unmistakable sadness. "And if you succeed, you will just plug back into your charging dock, waiting for the next assignment."

The red-hot heat from my chest seemed to have risen to my head. I screamed in fury. I pulled the gun on Preater and slammed the trigger as many times as I could count. There I sat, waiting beside my ship, and an ashy, still simmering black stain on the ground...

That was all I could remember till the guards tracked me down with the GPS fitted to my ship. Now sitting in my cell, with my fully grown beard, planning to break out, and break the loop.